



Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT) Basics

A 6-Module Self-Paced Educational Course

Learn how to understand and manage negative thought patterns using evidence-based CBT strategies.



Important Note

This course is for educational purposes only and does not replace professional therapy. If anxiety significantly interferes with your daily functioning (work, school, relationships) or includes panic attacks, trauma symptoms, or suicidal thoughts, please consult a licensed mental health professional or medical provider.

MODULE 1: What Is CBT?



Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, you will:

- Understand the difference between fear and anxiety
 - Learn what CBT is and how it works
 - Recognize the “vicious cycle” of anxiety
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1. Understanding Anxiety

Fear is a natural emotion that protects us from danger. Anxiety occurs when we experience fear even when no immediate danger is present.

As noted by the **Centre for Clinical Interventions (CCI)**:

“When we experience fear but we are not facing any real danger, we call this anxiety.” (CCI, 2018)

Anxiety becomes problematic when it:

- Occurs frequently
- Feels intense or overwhelming
- Interferes with daily life (work, school, church, socialising)

(Source: CCI, 2018; NIMH, 2023)

2. What Is CBT?

Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT) is an evidence-based psychological treatment that combines:

- **Cognitive Therapy** (working with thoughts)
- **Behavior Therapy** (working with behaviors)

CBT helps individuals:

- Identify unhelpful thinking patterns
- Change avoidance behaviors
- Develop coping skills
- Reduce anxiety symptoms

Research consistently shows CBT is effective for anxiety disorders (NIMH, 2023; WHO, 2023).

3. The Vicious Cycle of Anxiety

Anxiety is maintained through a cycle:

Trigger → Anxious Thought → Physical Symptoms → Avoidance → Temporary Relief → Increased Anxiety Later

Example (Jamaican context):

You feel anxious about presenting at UWI.

Thought: "Mi ago embarrass miself."

You avoid class.

Relief feels good.

Next presentation feels even worse.

Avoidance reinforces fear.

Exercise: Identify Your Cycle

Write:

- A recent anxious situation
 - The thought you had
 - What you did
 - What happened afterward
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Module 1 Sources

- Centre for Clinical Interventions. (2018). *CBT for Anxiety*. Government of Western Australia.
 - National Institute of Mental Health (2023). Anxiety Disorders.
<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/topics/anxiety-disorders>
 - World Health Organization (2023). Anxiety disorders fact sheet.
<https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/anxiety-disorders>
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MODULE 2: Understanding Thought Distortions

Objectives

- Identify common cognitive distortions
 - Learn how thoughts influence feelings
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1. The Cognitive Model

CBT teaches that:

Thoughts → Influence Feelings → Influence Behavior

Anxious people often make negative predictions:

“I won’t pass the exam.”
“People will think I’m stupid.”
“I’m going to have a heart attack.”

(CCI, 2018)

These predictions are often exaggerated or inaccurate.

2. Common Thought Distortions

1. Catastrophizing – Expecting the worst
2. Mind reading – Assuming others think negatively
3. Overgeneralization – “This always happens to me.”
4. All-or-nothing thinking – “If I’m not perfect, I’m a failure.”
5. Emotional reasoning – “I feel scared, so something must be wrong.”

Example:

“I didn’t get that job interview. Nobody will ever hire me.”



Exercise: Spot the Distortion

Write one anxious thought.

Which distortion fits?

Is there evidence for and against it?



Module 2 Sources

- Beck, J. S. (2021). *Cognitive Behavior Therapy: Basics and Beyond*.
 - CCI (2018). CBT for Anxiety.
 - NIMH (2023).
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MODULE 3: Thought Records & Cognitive Restructuring

Objectives

- Learn to challenge anxious thoughts
 - Practice balanced thinking
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1. Why Challenge Thoughts?

CCI explains that anxious individuals often believe they cannot cope with negative outcomes. CBT helps test these beliefs.

Most feared outcomes:

- Do not happen
 - Or are not as catastrophic as predicted (CCI, 2018)
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2. The Thought Record Tool

Step 1: Situation

Step 2: Automatic Thought

Step 3: Emotion (0–100%)

Step 4: Evidence For

Step 5: Evidence Against

Step 6: Balanced Thought

Example:

Situation: Staff meeting

Thought: “Mi ago sound foolish.”

Evidence For: I stumbled last time.

Evidence Against: People agreed with my idea before.

Balanced Thought: “I might feel nervous, but I can still contribute.”

Practice Worksheet

Complete one thought record this week.

Module 3 Sources

- CCI (2018).
 - Beck (2021).
 - Hofmann et al. (2012). *The efficacy of CBT: A review.*
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MODULE 4: Behavioral Activation

Objectives

- Understand avoidance
 - Learn to take small action steps
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Anxious individuals often avoid triggers to reduce anxiety. However:

Avoidance brings short-term relief but maintains anxiety long-term. (CCI, 2018)

Example:

Avoiding crowded plazas in Kingston reduces anxiety temporarily but increases fear over time.

Behavioral Activation Steps

1. Identify avoided activity
 2. Rate anxiety (0–10)
 3. Break into small steps
 4. Schedule it
 5. Reflect afterward
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Exercise

List one avoided activity.

What is the smallest possible step?

Module 4 Sources

- CCI (2018).
 - Martell et al. (2010). Behavioral Activation for Depression.
 - NIMH (2023).
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MODULE 5: Exposure Basics

Objectives

- Understand exposure therapy
 - Learn gradual exposure principles
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Exposure involves gradually facing feared situations instead of avoiding them.

CCI states:

Exposure is done in a gradual and controlled manner to learn tolerance and collect evidence about actual danger.

How Exposure Works

Anxiety rises → Peaks → Falls naturally

If you stay long enough, your nervous system recalibrates.

Creating an Exposure Ladder

Example: Fear of public speaking

1. Practice in mirror
 2. Record yourself
 3. Speak in small group
 4. Volunteer comment in meeting
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Important

Exposure should not be forced or rushed.
Severe anxiety disorders may require professional support.

Module 5 Sources

- CCI (2018).
 - Craske et al. (2014). Exposure Therapy for Anxiety.
 - WHO (2023).
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MODULE 6: Building Your Daily CBT Plan

Objectives

- Integrate cognitive and behavioral tools
 - Create a sustainable plan
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CBT may also include:

- Breathing retraining
 - Attention training
 - Structured problem-solving
(CCI, 2018)
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Daily CBT Framework

Morning:

- Identify potential stressors
- Write one balanced thought

During Day:

- Notice distortions

- Practice breathing

Evening:

- Complete one thought record
 - Reflect on avoided behaviors
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Confidence Building

CBT increases confidence by:

- Testing predictions
 - Gathering evidence
 - Reducing avoidance
 - Strengthening coping skills
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When to Seek Professional Help

If anxiety:

- Causes panic attacks
- Interferes with work/school
- Leads to substance use
- Includes hopelessness or suicidal thoughts

Seek professional care.

FULL COURSE REFERENCES (APA 7)

Beck, J. S. (2021). *Cognitive behavior therapy: Basics and beyond* (3rd ed.). Guilford Press.

Centre for Clinical Interventions. (2018). *CBT for anxiety*. Government of Western Australia.
<https://www.cci.health.wa.gov.au>

Craske, M. G., et al. (2014). Maximizing exposure therapy. *Behaviour Research and Therapy*, 58, 10–23.

Hofmann, S. G., et al. (2012). The efficacy of CBT: A review. *Cognitive Therapy and Research*, 36(5), 427–440.

National Institute of Mental Health. (2023). Anxiety disorders.

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/topics/anxiety-disorders>

World Health Organization. (2023). Anxiety disorders fact sheet.

<https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/anxiety-disorders>

Centre for Clinical Interventions. (n.d.). CBT for anxiety. Centre for Clinical Interventions.

<https://www.cci.health.wa.gov.au/~media/CCI/Mental-Health-Professionals/Anxiety/Anxiety---Information-Sheets/Anxiety-Information-Sheet---15---CBT-for-Anxiety.pdf>